

Mobile warriors
Young Zulu warriors were extremely fit and hardy. At war, they could cover 32km (20 miles) a day, which was double the speed achieved by the British army at that time. Although the Zulu carried throwing spears, clubs, and latterly firearms into battle, they relied chiefly on the cowhide shield and stabbing spear *(above and right)*.

IN THE EARLY 19TH CENTURY, the Zulu developed an aggressive warrior spirit and disciplined fighting skills that made them a dominant military power in their region of southern Africa. Despite their low level of technology, they proved difficult opponents for the British army in the Anglo-Zulu War of 1879, achieving a notable victory at Isandhlwana. But their mode of warfare, based on the spear and the shield, could not ultimately prevail in the face of the overwhelming firepower of rifles and artillery.

Before 1816, when they came under the rule of the paramount chief Shaka, the Zulu were an insignificant pastoral people with no pretensions to military excellence. They participated in the traditional warfare of the southern African cattle-herding tribes, which consisted of ritualized fighting that minimized casualties. When opposing sides met for battle, typically to decide a dispute over grazing land, individual warriors would demonstrate their prowess by challenging an enemy to single armed combat. Otherwise, the two sides would limit themselves first to an exchange of insults followed by the throwing of missiles at a distance. If their flimsy throwing spears managed to cause any deaths, warriors had to break off from combat to carry out cleansing rites to appease the spirits of the dead. The weaker side accepted defeat without insisting on a fight to the finish.

The development of the Zulu into a militaristic society began in the early 19th century under clan chief Dingiswayo, but it was only after chief Shaka seized power in 1816 that their practice of war was transformed. Shaka abandoned the traditional reliance on *assegais* (throwing spears) as the main weapon, instead introducing the stabbing spear and encouraging his warriors to use it to deadly effect in close combat. Instead of ritualized fighting, Shaka sought to fix and destroy the forces of his enemy. In a series of exterminatory campaigns, known as the *mfecane* ("crushing"), he massacred neighbouring peoples or forced them into submission. By the time of Shaka's death in 1828, the Zulu had spread almost as far north as Swaziland. The military machine, and style of warfare, that Shaka created remained broadly unchanged until the Zulu's disastrous encounter with the British Empire forces in 1879.

FORMING A WARRIOR

As young boys, future Zulu warriors picked up informal fighting skills by battling one another with sticks. They also learned to be hardy and self-reliant in their harsh natural environment, accompanying their elders as bearers on long cross-country journeys and hunting small game. Induction into the warrior class came between the ages of 18 and 20. Men of the same age group were assembled to form a regiment and set up a barracks. The warriors would remain with the same regiment – identified by the adoption of a particular colour shield and other details of dress – for the next two decades. Obviously, this regimental system encouraged bonding and group identity.

Although in the time of Shaka's rule warriors were, according to reports, trained in forced marches and military manoeuvres, there seems very little evidence at any later period for a tough training routine in the style of Western armies. In fact, the warriors' equivalent of parade-ground drill and weapons training appears to have largely consisted of performing complex rhythmic dances with shields, sticks, or spears.



COWHIDE SHIELD AND STABBING SPEAR